

TENRECS AND GOLDEN MOLES

Three families make up the order Afrosoricidae – the golden moles that are exclusively burrowers, the tenrecs and shrew tenrecs that have evolved into a variety of habitats, and the otter shrews that live in riverine and wetland areas.

Most species in this order are native to mainland Africa, with tenrecs also found in Madagascar. Golden moles are all very similar in appearance, with a cylindrical body and other anatomical adaptations to suit their burrowing lifestyle. In contrast, tenrecs display diverse characteristics that reflect the wide range of environments they occupy. Various species of tenrecs are found in tropical forests, where they may be terrestrial or semi-arboreal. The otter-shrews are aquatic, living in streams and rivers; and there

are also burrowing tenrecs. Until recently, tenrecs and golden moles were classified with true moles, shrews, and hedgehogs because of their largely insectivorous diet and often similar appearance. It is now known that the order Afrosoricida evolved independently and is most closely related to the elephants, hyraxes, and sirenians.

UNUSUAL FEATURES

Tenrecs and golden moles have features once considered primitive but now recognized as adaptations to harsh environments. Such features include a low metabolic rate and body temperature. These mammals also have the ability to enter a state of torpor – for up to three days – to save energy in cold conditions, and possess highly efficient kidneys, which reduce the need to drink water.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	MAMMALIA
ORDER	AFROSORICIDA
FAMILIES	3
SPECIES	55



A Grant's golden mole feasts on a locust. At night it forages for food on the surface, feeding mainly on termites.

GOLDEN MOLES

These moles resemble both true moles (Talpidae) from Europe, Asia, and North America, and marsupial moles (Notoryctemorphia) from Australia, as all have similar burrowing habits. The Chrysochloridae from southern Africa have short legs with powerful digging claws, dense fur that repels moisture, and toughened skin, especially on the head. They have non-functional eyes covered with skin, and lack external ears.



JULIANA'S GOLDEN MOLE

Neamblysomus julianae

Unique to the dry highlands of South Africa, typically in sandy soils, this species frequents well-irrigated gardens within its range.

9–12 cm
3½–4¾ in

CAPE GOLDEN MOLE

Chrysochloris asiatica

Although secretive, this is a common species in parts of South Africa. It uses the enlarged second toe on its front feet for digging.

leathery pad
protects nostrils
and aids burrowing

eyes covered with
thick layer of skin

webbed toes to
kick soil backwards

HOTTENTOT GOLDEN MOLE

Amblysomus hottentotus

This golden mole inhabits tunnel systems up to 200 m (655 ft) long, using the large second and third toes on its front feet for digging.



GRANT'S DESERT GOLDEN MOLE

Eremitalpa granti

Inhabiting the southwest African coastal dunes, one of the world's driest habitats, this species "swims" through sand rather than building tunnels.

